

■ By Amitabh Srivastava

Making a pass. Wielding a stick. Body checking. Much before Kabir Khan of last year's inspirational *Chak De! India*, there was a retired employee of the Ranchi-based Heavy Engineering Corporation (HEC) who knew next to nothing about the national game. Brij Nandan Prasad's tryst with hockey started accidentally in 1980 when

team WORKER

✱ B.N. Prasad, 66

Project Promoting hockey among tribal women

Can-do Icon The Jharkhand women's hockey team for their never-say-die approach

The Women's National hockey team hit gold three years in a row from 2002 at the Commonwealth Games, the Afro-Asian Games and the Asia Cup

was with HEC. He watched as a group of tribal girls raced towards the goal at an inter-university hockey tournament. He was hooked. He started following the game avidly and travelled to Delhi to watch the 1982 Asian Games. But even as he cheered when the Indian women's team won the gold, he wondered why there wasn't one tribal girl in the entire Indian team? It was a question that changed his life.

Prasad spoke to Kartar Singh, the then secretary of the Indian Women's Hockey Federation. "He said he knew Bihar had quality hockey players and asked me to start a state association to propel the players to the national level. I had no sanction to this effect but I submitted an application," he recalls. Back in Ranchi, Prasad got a word from Delhi that they were looking for four best hockey players from the state for a national training camp. "It was a huge responsibility and I didn't know anyone in this regard. So I approached the Ranchi University. The authorities agreed to bear the travel expenditure, provided their players were sent. I agreed," he adds.

A month later, Prasad realised his mistake when none of the girls was selected in the national squad. The next year, he got a second chance to prove his mettle. Prasad cherry-picked the girls this time, Alma Gudiya, Dayami Soy, Savitri Puri and Vishwati Puri, to be sent to Delhi. The finances were arranged from his provident fund—Rs 1,000. At that time he was drawing a monthly salary of Rs 700. Savitri was chosen for the national team and his Women's Hockey

Association got an affiliation.

This was not the only time when Prasad had to withdraw money from his provident fund to finance the expenses of the team. But the successes they notched up kept him going. Bihar finally got to play the junior nationals in December 1983. "We won," says Prasad, and he did it without being a tactician or having any formal training as a coach—something of a prerequisite. For a father figure to the girls, he would skimp on his food to buy ice-creams for the girls. His house became a second home to them and his wife a surrogate mother.

The next big draw came in 1984, when the Jharkhand junior women's hockey team, with three senior players, was sent to play the women's nationals in Shimla. This time Prasad borrowed Rs 4,000 from his provident fund account. The team lost in the quarter finals but not before beating the hosts by 11-0. "Before the match, the Himachal players were heckling our girls because they were dark, wore worn-out skirts and didn't know English. After we won, one of our girls told them—Don't look at our faces. Watch our sticks," he recalls. Back home, people had started recognising their efforts and the state Government announced a cash award of Rs 10,000. The next year, success came when the Bihar Government agreed to recruit the entire junior team, many less than 18, as constables. Prasad took 16 tribal girls to Patna for the recruitment process and withdrew Rs 10,000 from his provident fund for the trip. The journey allowed the girls, most of whom were from